

Quinnipiac Staff Member Brings Back Podcast Series to Cast Spotlight on 9/11 Journalists

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OCTOBER 10, 2023 / 2:39 P.M. EDT / Q30TV NEWS

Hamden, CT – To commemorate the 22nd anniversary of the terrorist attacks on September 11, 2001, a staff member at Quinnipiac University is releasing new episodes of their award-winning podcast series, “Reporting on 9/11”.

Launched in 2021 by the assistant dean of the School of Communications, Ben Bogardus, the podcast highlights the personal experiences of journalists covering the attacks as they happened and uncovers the long-term effects it had on both their personal and professional lives.

During a recent press conference at Quinnipiac, Bogardus answered several questions from students in the COM 140 (Storytelling) class, discussing his motives for creating the podcast and what he hopes will result from it.

Bogardus, who has a background in journalism, explained that while working in Washington D.C. from 2007 to 2010, many of his colleagues at the news station would recount their experiences from the day of the attacks. After hearing these stories, he was inspired to begin a new project.

“I was like, ‘You know, this needs to be reported. This needs to be saved for [the] future,’” said Bogardus. “These are unique stories... so getting them to open up and share those in documents... was something I had wanted to do since then.”

Across 13 episodes, “Reporting on 9/11” takes a documentary-style approach to a podcast by taking the interview and adding elements, including sound effects, music and sound bites to enhance the audience’s experience.

As a result, listeners have grown to admire and appreciate not just the professional quality, but also the impactful stories of the journalists.

Joe Little, TV reporter for KNSD NBC 7 in San Diego, shared his story about capturing the first recorded footage of Flight 93’s crash site near Shanksville, Pennsylvania.

Little explained that on September 11, he was tasked with driving two hours to interview a Vietnam War veteran for a local news station. By the time they arrived, he was already aware of the crash into the World Trade Center, and shortly after, he was informed by his boss that a plane had crashed six miles away.

After following first responders in their news truck, Little ran towards the scene, where he would take the first ever video of Flight 93 after it crashed. He considers this an event that “every journalist dreams of [capturing],” and adds that there are unfortunately going to be tragic events every day, but very few have a significant impact on world history. This was the exception.

Additionally, the series also explores the motivations of news reporters and why they react in the heat of the moment, even when confronted with adversities.

Retired news reporter Suzanne Kennedy of WJLA ABC 7 in Washington D.C. was one of the first guests on the podcast, and she recalled exploring the aftermath directly after the attack on the Pentagon, despite being four months pregnant.

“As a journalist, you’re heading right into [danger] all the time, no matter what it is,” said Kennedy. “I think there is a part of you—as a journalist—where the adrenaline sort of tells you, ‘Just do it, and don’t think about it.’”

Over the last year, “Reporting on 9/11” has received multiple accolades, including the 2022 Leibner Cooper Grant for Creative Productions on the History of Media. Ben Bogardus expressed his gratitude and what it means to him to produce a podcast that has received this amount of recognition.

“The reason I did it is to share stories and to document it and memorialize it,” said Bogardus. “So, the fact that it’s being recognized and people do see value in it is something that I’m very proud of, more proud of than the actual success of the show.”

All three seasons of “Reporting on 9/11” are available on Apple, Spotify, and other major podcast providers.

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